

Position Paper

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Is Rizal Still the Ideal Filipino Hero Today?

The Philippines has no shortage of heroes, people who gave their lives, their freedom, or their comfort for the sake of their country. But for over a century, one name has stood above the rest as the national hero: Jose Protacio Rizal Mercado y Alonso Realonda. He never led a revolution. He never carried a weapon into battle. What he did was write, study, and speak the truth at a time when doing so could get a person killed, and eventually, it did. Today, however, some Filipinos question whether Rizal is still the right person to hold that title. Is a 19th-century ilustrado still someone the modern Filipino should look up to? The answer, after careful thought, is yes. Rizal remains the ideal Filipino hero today, not because he is a perfect figure from a perfect past, but because the values he lived by address problems that have never really gone away. His relevance is not historical; it is ongoing.

First and most fundamentally, the injustices Rizal fought against are not buried in the past, they are present realities. In *Noli Me Tangere* and *El Filibusterismo*, he exposed a society where ordinary Filipinos were crushed under a system that protected the powerful and punished those who questioned it. He wrote about abusive officials, indifferent institutions, and a people so conditioned by oppression that they struggled to recognize their own dignity (Zaide & Zaide, 1999). That description still fits far too much of Philippine society today. Cases of land grabbing, political dynasties that span generations, and the silencing of journalists and activists all echo the same structures Rizal critiqued more than a century ago. His novels read less like historical fiction and

more like a mirror held up to the present. The fact that they still sting when you read them is proof that the wound they describe has not fully healed.

Second, Rizal's life was a demonstration of something that Philippine public life urgently needs more of: integrity. He did not just write about the problems of his country from a comfortable distance, he returned to face those problems himself, knowing the risks. When he came back to the Philippines in 1892 after years of study in Europe, he was fully aware that his novels had made him an enemy of the colonial government. He founded the La Liga Filipina, was immediately arrested, and spent years in exile in Dapitan before ultimately being executed at the age of 35 (Guerrero, 1962). He could have stayed in Spain, continued writing, and lived safely. He chose not to. That kind of consistency between belief and action is rare in any era, but it is especially rare in the Philippines today, where public figures often say one thing and do another. Rizal does not just represent this quality in the abstract, his life is its most well-documented example in Philippine history.

Third, Rizal's insistence on education as the foundation of genuine freedom is still the most important and unfinished project in the Philippines. He believed that a people who could not think critically for themselves could not be truly free, and he dedicated his entire life to learning; medicine, languages, the arts, the sciences, not for personal prestige, but to be more useful to his nation (Ocampo, 1990). That belief is not outdated; it is a direct challenge to a country that still ranks poorly in international assessments of reading comprehension and critical thinking. In an age where

misinformation spreads rapidly and is so often believed, the Filipino youth's ability to question, verify, and reason has never mattered more. Rizal's call to educate oneself, not just to memorize facts for an exam, but to truly understand the world is not something students can afford to treat as a historical footnote. It is a task that remains incomplete.

Counterarguments

A significant counterargument is that Rizal is no longer the most relevant hero for modern Filipinos because the world he lived in no longer exists. The Spanish colonial system is gone. The specific abuses he wrote about; friar landlords, corrupt alcaldes, a colonial government that treated Filipinos as second-class subjects are not the direct problems Filipinos face today. Some critics go further, arguing that Andres Bonifacio deserves more recognition as the "true" hero of the Filipino people precisely because he came from the working class and actually fought, whereas Rizal was a member of the elite who initially sought reform within the colonial system rather than revolution against it (Ileto, 1998). From this perspective, elevating Rizal above all other heroes is a choice that reflects the biases of those who made that decision, not necessarily the values Filipinos most need today.

This critique is worth taking seriously, because it is historically grounded. Bonifacio's contribution to Philippine freedom is real and should never be minimized. However, the argument that Rizal is irrelevant because Spanish colonialism ended misses the point of what Rizal actually stood for. He was not just fighting Spanish friars,

he was fighting the conditions that allowed oppression to persist: ignorance, passivity, and a culture that accepted injustice as normal. Those conditions did not disappear when Spain left. If anything, they have proven remarkably durable. The question of which hero the Philippines should honor most is ultimately not about who fought the hardest, but about whose example most challenges the living generation. By that measure, Rizal's model of an educated, principled, truth-telling citizen is one the Philippines still desperately needs not because it is comfortable, but precisely because it is demanding.

Conclusion

Rizal is not the ideal Filipino hero because a law declares him so, or because his face appears on the peso bill. He is the ideal hero because the values he embodied, fighting injustice through truth, living with integrity even when it costs everything, and believing in the transformative power of education are not values that expire. They are needed in every generation, and perhaps most of all in this one. His flaws are real, and honest engagement with them only strengthens the argument: a hero who was human, who struggled, and who still chose to stand by his convictions is far more instructive than a mythologized saint. The lesson of Rizal's life is not that the Philippines already has what it takes. The lesson is that it is still being built, and that building it requires exactly the kind of courage, clarity, and commitment that Rizal demonstrated. That lesson has not been fully learned yet, and until it is, Rizal remains as relevant as ever.

References

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